# Part 2 · Reading Language Arts

## How Grade 8 RLA Is Built

The Grade 8 Reading Language Arts test has about **45 questions worth 56 points** in two sections, plus written responses. This book teaches **every reading and writing skill the test measures.**

| Section | What It Covers | On the Test |
|---|---|---|
| **Reading** | Vocabulary, comprehension, literary elements, genres, author's craft; includes **2 Short Constructed Responses** | ~28 Q / ~30 pts |
| **Writing — Revising & Editing** | Organizing and improving writing; grammar and conventions; includes **1 Extended Constructed Response** | ~17 Q / ~26 pts |

### Three Kinds of Tasks

1. **Multiple-choice and tech-enhanced questions** about passages you read.
2. **Short Constructed Responses (SCR)** — a few written sentences with text evidence (2 points each).
3. **Extended Constructed Response (ECR)** — a full essay (10 points), tied to a reading passage.

### Genres You Will Read

- **Literary:** fiction, literary nonfiction, poetry, drama
- **Informational / argumentative:** informational, argumentative, persuasive
- **In revising & editing:** correspondence (letters, emails)

> **Key Idea:** Reading STAAR is not about memorizing stories — it is about **using evidence.** Almost every question can be answered by pointing to a specific place in the text. Read closely and back up every answer with proof.

# Genre Guide

STAAR passages come from many genres, and each has its own features to notice. Knowing the genre tells you what to look for. (Standards 8A–8E.)

## Literary Genres

- **Fiction ○ (8A)** — made-up stories: realistic, historical, mystery, adventure, humor, fantasy, science fiction, short stories. *Notice:* characters, setting, conflict, plot, theme.
- **Literary Nonfiction** — true stories told with literary craft (memoir, personal essay). *Notice:* the real experience and its message.
- **Poetry ○ (8B)** — lines and stanzas; forms include epic, lyric, humorous. *Notice:* **graphical elements** such as line length and punctuation, plus rhythm, rhyme, imagery.
- **Drama ○ (8C)** — plays organized in **acts and scenes** with dialogue and stage directions. *Notice:* how acts and scenes move the action.

## Informational and Argumentative Genres

- **Informational (8D)** — explains a topic. *Notice:* the **controlling idea/thesis** with evidence ★; features like **footnotes, endnotes, citations** ○; the **organizational pattern** ○.
- **Argumentative (8E)** — makes a claim and defends it. *Notice:* the **claim** ★, the **counter-argument** ★, and the **intended audience** ○.
- **Persuasive** — tries to convince. *Notice:* appeals, word choice, calls to action.

## For Revising & Editing

- **Correspondence** — letters and emails, friendly or business. *Notice:* greeting, purpose, tone, closing.

> **Strategy:** The first thing to ask about any passage is *"What genre is this, and what is its purpose?"* A story wants you to follow characters and theme; an argument wants you to weigh a claim and its evidence.

# Reading Strategy Lessons

These lessons teach the reading skills STAAR tests again and again. Each is tagged with its TEKS and marked ★ **Readiness** or ○ **Supporting**.

## Part A · Vocabulary (2A ○, 2B ★, 2C ○)

- **2B · Context clues** ★ — Read the words around an unfamiliar word: definitions, examples, synonyms, antonyms, and the sentence's sense point to the meaning.
- **2A · Reference tools** ○ — A dictionary/glossary gives meaning, syllables, pronunciation, origin, part of speech. (A dictionary is available on the real test.)
- **2C · Greek & Latin roots** ○ — **ast** (star → astronomy), **qui** (rest → tranquil), **path** (feeling → sympathy), **mand/mend** (order → command), **duc** (lead → conduct).

**Worked example.** "The *arid* desert had not seen rain in years." *Arid* = very dry — the context shows it. **Try It.** "His *gregarious* nature made him the center of every party." *(Outgoing/sociable.)*

## Part B · Comprehension (5C ○, 5E ★, 5F ★, 5G ★, 5H ★)

- **5F · Inference + evidence** ★ — A smart conclusion from text clues + prior knowledge; always find the supporting words.
- **5G · Key ideas** ★ — Separate the main point from small details. **5H · Synthesize** ★ — Combine ideas (one text or across two) into new understanding.
- **5E · Make connections** ★ — Link text to other texts, the world, and experience. **5C · Predictions** ○ — Predict from genre and features, then confirm or correct.

**Worked example.** A character "slammed the door and refused to speak" → **infer** she is angry; the evidence is her actions. **Try It.** Sky darkens, wind rises, people hurry indoors → *a storm is coming.*

## Part C · Response to Reading (6C ★, 6D ★)

- **6C · Text evidence** ★ — Support every answer with a specific word, phrase, or sentence. This is the heart of STAAR reading.
- **6D · Paraphrase & summarize** ★ — Restate in your own words (paraphrase) or give a short, ordered version of the main points (summarize), keeping meaning accurate.

**Strategy:** For "Which sentence **best** supports…?" decide your answer first, then find the line that *directly* proves it — not one that is merely true.

## Part D · Literary Elements (7A ○, 7B ★, 7C ★, 7D ○)

- **7B · Character motivation** ★ — Why characters act, and how that drives events and the conflict's resolution.
- **7C · Non-linear plot** ★ — **Flashback**, **foreshadowing**, subplots, parallel plots — vs. straight linear order.

- **7A · Theme** ○ — The message, developed through characters and events. **7D · Setting** ○ — When/where, and how it shapes values and beliefs.

**Try It.** A story opens at a funeral, then jumps back to the character's childhood. What device? *(Flashback.)*

## Part E · Author's Purpose and Craft (9A ★, 9B–9G ○)

- **9A · Purpose & message** ★ — To inform, persuade, or entertain — and the message within.
- **9B · Text structure** ○ — Cause–effect, compare–contrast, sequence, problem–solution. **9C · Print/graphic features** ○ — Headings, captions, charts, and why.
- **9D · Figurative language** ○ — Simile, metaphor (incl. extended metaphor), personification. **9E · Devices** ○ — Irony and multiple points of view.
- **9F · Mood, voice, tone** ○ — The feeling, the author's personality, the attitude toward the subject. **9G · Rhetoric & fallacies** ○ — Analogy, juxtaposition; bandwagon, circular reasoning.

**Worked example (tone).** "cramped, gloomy, endless" → a **negative, heavy tone.** **Try It.** "Everyone is switching to BrightSmile — don't be left behind!" Which fallacy? *(Bandwagon appeal.)*

## Reading Skills Checklist

- ☐ 2A–C Vocabulary · ☐ 5C–H Comprehension · ☐ 6C–D Response
- ☐ 7A–D Literary elements · ☐ 9A–G Author's craft